

Market Requirements Document: Prism Construction Payroll for SMB Contractors

1. Executive Summary

1.1 The Strategic Imperative

The construction industry stands at a critical juncture of technological transformation and regulatory intensification. For Small and Medium-Sized Businesses (SMBs) in the construction sector—specifically those with fewer than 50 employees—payroll is not merely an administrative burden; it is an existential risk management function. Unlike generic retail or service industries, construction payroll is governed by a labyrinthine matrix of federal statutes, state-specific labor codes, union collective bargaining agreements (CBAs), and project-specific mandates such as the Davis-Bacon Act.¹

For the uninitiated contractor, often a skilled tradesperson who has transitioned into business ownership, the penalty for failure in this domain is severe. Misclassification of workers, failure to pay prevailing wages, or incorrect calculation of overtime across variable pay rates can lead to restitution payments, civil penalties, and debarment from future government contracts.¹ Yet, the current market solutions fail to serve this specific demographic. Generalist payroll platforms like QuickBooks and Gusto offer excellent usability but lack the depth to handle "fully burdened" labor costing or certified payroll reporting natively.² Conversely, legacy construction ERPs like Vista or Foundation are powerful but suffer from high total cost of ownership, steep learning curves, and user interfaces that alienate the modern, mobile-first workforce.⁴

Prism Construction Payroll is proposed as the bridge across this chasm. This product aims to democratize enterprise-grade financial control for the SMB contractor. By leveraging the existing Prism accounting framework, this new module will deliver a "service-first" payroll experience. The core philosophy is "**Complexity Abstraction**": the system will handle the intricate calculus of multi-state reciprocity, weighted average overtime, and union fringes in the background, presenting the user with a simplified, intuitive interface that requires no deep knowledge of payroll regulations.⁶

1.2 Market Opportunity and Dynamics

The United States construction industry is a massive economic engine, contributing approximately \$2.2 trillion in annual gross output and employing over 8.2 million individuals as of 2024.⁸ Structurally, it is heavily fragmented. Of the estimated 3.7 million construction

businesses, the vast majority are small enterprises. Data indicates that over 640,000 establishments employ fewer than 5 people, highlighting a massive "micro-business" segment that is underserved by enterprise software.⁹

The total addressable market (TAM) for SMB software is projected to grow from \$74.5 billion in 2025 to over \$150 billion by 2035, driven by a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of over 7.5%.¹⁰ Within this, the construction payroll niche is expanding rapidly due to three converging forces:

1. **Regulatory Pressure:** The federal push for infrastructure renewal comes with strings attached—specifically, strict adherence to prevailing wage laws. Small contractors wishing to bid on these lucrative contracts must adopt compliant payroll systems or risk non-compliance.¹²
2. **Labor Scarcity:** With 228,000 jobs added in the last year alone, the competition for skilled labor is fierce. SMBs must offer professional, timely, and transparent payment experiences (including mobile pay stubs and diverse benefit options) to retain talent against larger competitors.⁷
3. **The Digital Handover:** As older owners retire, a new generation of digital-native leaders is taking over. This cohort rejects manual spreadsheets and "clunky" legacy systems, demanding the same user experience (UX) quality they encounter in consumer apps.⁴

1.3 Key Objectives and Success Metrics

The primary objective of Prism Payroll is to capture the "Compliance-Conscious SMB"—contractors who are outgrowing spreadsheets but are intimidated by full-scale ERPs.

- **Adoption Goal:** Achieve a 40% attach rate within the existing Prism accounting user base within the first 18 months.¹⁵
- **Efficiency Goal:** Reduce the time SMB owners spend on weekly payroll administration by 50% through automated time-card-to-check workflows.³
- **Compliance Goal:** Eliminate 100% of common calculation errors related to overtime and prevailing wage differentials for users of the platform.¹⁶

2. Market Analysis: The Reality of SMB Construction

2.1 The "Hodgepodge" Tech Stack

Research into the current behaviors of SMB contractors reveals a fragmented and inefficient technology landscape. Small contractors often utilize a "hodgepodge" of disconnected tools to manage their business. A typical stack might include QuickBooks Online for accounting, a standalone timekeeping app like TSheets (now QuickBooks Time) or ExakTime, and a third-party payroll processor like ADP or Paychex.⁶

This fragmentation creates data silos. Time is collected in one app, approved in a

spreadsheet, and then manually keyed into the payroll system. This manual transcription is the primary vector for data entry errors, leading to incorrect paychecks and inaccurate job costing.⁶ Interviews indicate that while owners desire integration, they are often paralyzed by the cost and complexity of migrating to a unified platform. "It's hard to find the right fit," notes one stakeholder, highlighting that generalist tools lack construction logic, while specialist tools lack modern usability.⁴

2.2 The Compliance Trap

The defining characteristic of the construction payroll market is the "Compliance Trap." As SMBs grow, they often take on public works projects to secure steady revenue. However, these projects trigger the Davis-Bacon Act, requiring the submission of Certified Payroll Reports (Form WH-347).

Standard payroll providers (e.g., Gusto, ADP Run) operate on a "per-employee" model that handles taxes well but struggles with the concept of "projects." They typically cannot natively generate a WH-347 that maps specific hours to specific federal work classifications. Consequently, the SMB owner is forced to pay for payroll software and *still* spend hours manually creating compliance reports in Excel. This creates a high-churn environment where dissatisfied contractors are constantly seeking a solution that understands their specific reality.¹²

2.3 Economic Pressures and Cash Flow

Cash flow management is a critical pain point. In construction, payment terms are often Net-30 or Net-60, meaning contractors must front the cost of labor and materials for months before receiving payment. Payroll, however, is an immediate and non-negotiable cash outflow. Weekly payroll cycles are common in construction to satisfy state labor laws and union agreements, exacerbating this cash flow crunch.⁶

A payroll solution for this market must essentially function as a cash flow management tool. It must provide real-time visibility into labor liabilities—not just gross wages, but the "fully burdened" cost including employer taxes and workers' compensation premiums—so that owners can accurately project their cash needs against their accounts receivable.¹

3. User Personas and Behavioral Profiles

To build a solution that is "easy to use" and "intuitive," we must deeply understand the actors within the system. In the SMB segment, roles are fluid; the owner often acts as the CFO, HR Manager, and Payroll Clerk simultaneously.

3.1 Primary Persona: The "Overwhelmed Operator" (Owner/Office Manager)

- **Demographics:** Owner of a firm with 5–25 employees, or a trusted Office Manager (often a family member) managing the back office.
- **Psychographics:** Highly risk-averse regarding taxes and compliance but technically conservative. They prefer "tried and true" methods over "bleeding edge" tech. They view payroll as a terrifying necessity rather than a strategic function.⁶
- **Key Responsibilities:**
 - Collecting timecards from the field (often via text or paper).
 - Verifying hours against job progress.
 - Cutting checks or initiating direct deposits.
 - Handling tax notices and workers' compensation audits.
- **Pain Points:**
 - **Fear of the IRS:** They live in constant fear of miscalculating a tax deposit or misclassifying a worker, knowing that penalties can bankrupt the business.²¹
 - **The "Friday Crunch":** Payroll must be done by Friday. Any delay in data collection from the field creates a high-stress bottleneck at the end of the week.²¹
 - **Disconnect from Field Reality:** They often lack visibility into what is actually happening on the job site, leading to disputes over hours worked.⁴
- **Product Needs:** A system that acts as a "safety net." They need automated alerts (e.g., "You missed a tax filing"), guided workflows ("Wizards"), and a support team that understands construction, not just software.²²

3.2 Secondary Persona: The "Muddy Boots" Supervisor (Foreman)

- **Demographics:** Crew lead responsible for 5–15 workers. Works on-site, often in harsh conditions. Not primarily a desk worker.
- **Psychographics:** Pragmatic and skeptical of administrative tasks. Views paperwork as an obstacle to "real work." Low tolerance for apps that require multiple clicks or complex navigation.⁵
- **Key Responsibilities:**
 - Ensuring the crew is on-site and working.
 - Tracking material usage and progress.
 - Submitting time for the crew (often doing it *for* them to ensure they get paid).
- **Pain Points:**
 - **Data Entry Friction:** Hates typing on a small screen with dirty hands or in bright sunlight.
 - **Coding Complexity:** Struggles to remember which specific "Cost Code" (e.g., 03-3000 Concrete) applies to the day's work, leading to default/lazy coding ("Just put it all to General Labor").⁵
- **Product Needs:** A mobile interface with large buttons, voice-to-text capabilities, and smart defaults (e.g., geo-fencing that suggests the job based on location).

3.3 Tertiary Persona: The External Gatekeeper (CPA/Bookkeeper)

- **Demographics:** Independent accountant retained by the SMB for quarterly reviews and tax preparation.
- **Psychographics:** Detail-oriented, focused on GAAP compliance and reconciliation. Skeptical of new software that might mess up the General Ledger (GL).
- **Key Responsibilities:**
 - Reconciling bank statements with payroll ledgers.
 - Preparing corporate tax returns.
 - Advising the owner on financial health.
- **Pain Points:**
 - **Messy Data:** Spending billable hours cleaning up miscategorized expenses or untangling commingled funds.
 - **Lack of Access:** Waiting for the owner to send PDF reports instead of having direct access to the system.¹⁵
- **Product Needs:** A dedicated "Accountant Portal" with read-only access to reports, seamless GL integration (export to QuickBooks/Sage), and audit trails.²³

4. Competitor Analysis and Strategic Positioning

The market landscape is polarized. On one end are the generic SMB giants (QuickBooks, ADP); on the other are the specialized construction ERPs (Foundation, Vista). Prism's opportunity lies in the "Missing Middle."

4.1 The Generalist SMB Players

QuickBooks Payroll (Intuit)

- **Market Position:** The dominant player, holding over 62% of the SMB accounting market.²⁴
- **Strengths:** Ubiquity, massive ecosystem of integrations, ease of use, brand trust.
- **Weaknesses:** Job costing is rudimentary. It struggles with "weighted average overtime" calculations required for employees working multiple rates. It relies on third-party integrations (like TSheets) for advanced time tracking, which can be disjointed. It does not handle union fringe benefits natively.²⁶
- **Prism's Advantage:** Native, deep job costing that treats labor as a project expense first, and a payroll liability second.

Gusto

- **Market Position:** The modern challenger, beloved for its UX/UI and "people-first" branding.²⁷
- **Strengths:** Incredible ease of use, automated tax filings, transparent pricing (\$40 base + \$6/user).
- **Weaknesses:** Lacks construction DNA. While it has added some "job costing" features, they are lightweight. It cannot handle complex certified payroll reporting formats

(WH-347) without manual workarounds. It is not designed for the transient, project-based workforce of construction.³

- **Prism's Advantage:** Specialization. Prism will offer the compliance tools (Certified Payroll) that Gusto ignores because they are too niche for Gusto's broad target market.

ADP Run

- **Market Position:** The behemoth of payroll, scaling from 1 to 1,000+ employees.²⁸
- **Strengths:** Reliability, massive support network, handles multi-state tax filing well.
- **Weaknesses:** Often criticized for opaque pricing ("Call for Quote"). The interface can feel corporate and sterile. While they offer "Construction" bundles, they are often just the standard product with a few extra fields, not a purpose-built solution.²⁸
- **Prism's Advantage:** Transparency and integration. Prism will offer clear, flat pricing and deeper integration with the Prism Accounting suite than ADP can offer via API.

4.2 The Construction Specialists

Foundation Software / Payroll4Construction

- **Market Position:** The incumbent for heavy construction payroll.²
- **Strengths:** Handles every conceivable construction complexity (Union, Multi-State, Certified).
- **Weaknesses:** The UX is dated (often resembling spreadsheets or Windows 95 interfaces). It is expensive and complex to implement, often overkill for a 10-person remodeling contractor.⁴
- **Prism's Advantage:** Usability. Prism aims to deliver 80% of Foundation's power with 100% of Gusto's usability.

4.3 Strategic Positioning Statement

For small to medium-sized construction contractors **who** struggle to balance payroll compliance with project profitability, **Prism Payroll** is a specialized financial management solution **that** integrates time tracking, payroll processing, and job costing into a single automated workflow. **Unlike** QuickBooks or ADP, Prism is built on the logic of construction, treating every labor hour as a vital piece of project intelligence, not just a line item on a paycheck.

5. High-Level Capabilities and Functional Requirements

The system must balance power with simplicity. It must hide the complexity of the engine under the hood of a sleek dashboard.

5.1 Capability Set 1: Foundational Compliance and Onboarding

The "Bedrock" of the system. If the setup is wrong, every paycheck will be wrong.¹

- **Requirements:**

- **Multi-Jurisdictional Logic:** The system must allow users to enter their Federal EIN once, but support unlimited State/Local tax IDs. Critically, it must prompt the user: "You added a job site in Ohio; do you have an Ohio withholding ID?" This proactive guidance prevents non-compliance.¹
- **Digital Onboarding Flow:** A paperless wizard for new hires to complete Forms I-9 and W-4 via their mobile device. The system must verify that fields are complete before allowing the employee to be paid.
- **Worker Classification Guardrails:** A built-in "wizard" that helps owners determine if a worker is a W-2 Employee or 1099 Contractor based on IRS common law factors (Behavioral Control, Financial Control). This reduces the risk of misclassification penalties.¹
- **Flexible Pay Calendars:** Support for Weekly, Bi-Weekly, and Semi-Monthly pay periods. It must include logic that warns users if their selected frequency violates state laws for manual laborers (e.g., California requires specific frequencies for construction workers).¹

5.2 Capability Set 2: Advanced Time Data Collection

The "Input Layer." Accurate payroll requires accurate time data from the field.

- **Requirements:**

- **Mobile Punch Clock:** A native iOS/Android app. It must support "Offline Mode" for remote job sites with poor connectivity, syncing data once connection is restored.⁵
- **Geofencing & Biometrics:** To prevent "buddy punching" (one worker clocking in for another), the app should capture GPS coordinates at clock-in. If the worker is outside the geofence of the Job Site, the punch is flagged for manager review. Optional facial recognition or photo capture upon clock-in adds another layer of security.¹
- **Granular Cost Coding:** Users must be able to clock into a specific Job (Project) and a specific Cost Code (Task, e.g., "Framing"). To maintain usability, the app should only display Cost Codes relevant to that specific project or employee trade, reducing the "scroll fatigue" of finding the right code.¹
- **Crew Functionality:** A "Foreman Mode" allowing a supervisor to clock in an entire crew at once, or distribute hours for the crew at the end of the day. This aligns with the workflow of many SMBs where individual workers may not have smartphones or data plans.⁵

5.3 Capability Set 3: The Calculation Engine

The "Brain." This engine must handle construction-specific math that breaks generic systems.

- **Requirements:**

- **Variable Pay Rates:** The system must support unlimited pay rates per employee. A

worker might earn \$25/hr for shop work but \$45/hr for field work. The system must automatically select the correct rate based on the Cost Code selected during time entry.¹

- **Weighted Average Overtime (WAOT):** When an employee works at multiple rates in a single week and exceeds 40 hours, the system must automatically calculate the weighted average regular rate to determine the correct overtime premium, complying with FLSA standards.¹
- **Prevailing Wage Automation:** The system must allow users to input "Wage Determinations" for public works projects. If an employee works on a certified job, the system must automatically override their base rate with the federally mandated prevailing rate for that classification.¹
- **Labor Burden Calculation:** The engine must calculate the "True Cost" of every labor hour. This means adding the employer's share of FICA, FUTA, SUI, Workers' Compensation premiums, and General Liability insurance to the gross wage. This fully burdened cost is what must be posted to the Job Cost ledger.¹

5.4 Capability Set 4: Disbursement and Reporting

The "Output Layer." Getting money to workers and data to the government.

- **Requirements:**
 - **Flexible Payment Rails:** Support for 2-day or Next-Day Direct Deposit (ACH). Crucially, the system must also support on-site check printing. In construction, many workers still prefer or require physical checks. The system should generate a PDF check face compatible with standard check stock.¹⁴
 - **Split Payments:** Ability for employees to split their net pay across multiple accounts (e.g., Checking and Savings).¹
 - **Detailed Pay Stubs:** Pay stubs must be transparent, showing the breakdown of hours worked at *each* pay rate, job location, and specific deductions. This transparency is vital for building trust with the workforce.¹
 - **Certified Payroll Reporting (CPR):** One-click generation of the Federal Form WH-347. The system acts as a "translator," taking the raw payroll data and formatting it into the rigid structure required by the DOL. This saves hours of manual transcription.¹
 - **Automated Tax Filing:** The system acts as a reporting agent, automatically withholding, filing, and depositing federal (941/940), state, and local taxes. This "peace of mind" is a primary selling point for the "Overwhelmed Operator".¹

5.5 Capability Set 5: Job Cost Integration

The "Strategic Advantage." This connects payroll to the broader business health.

- **Requirements:**
 - **Real-Time GL Sync:** Payroll data must sync to the General Ledger (GL) instantly.

Direct labor costs should debit "Cost of Goods Sold," while office labor debits "Overhead Expenses."

- **Budget vs. Actuals:** A dashboard widget showing "Estimated Labor Hours" vs. "Actual Labor Hours" for active projects. This feedback loop allows Project Managers to intervene before a project goes over budget.¹

6. Technical Architecture and "Build vs. Buy"

To meet the requirement of "easy to maintain" and rapid time-to-market, we cannot build everything from scratch.

6.1 The "Service-First" Architecture

We will adopt a hybrid architecture that separates the "Construction Logic" (our core competency) from the "Commodity Payroll Logic" (tax tables and money movement).

- **Build (Internal Core):**
 - **Time Collection Interface:** We must own the mobile app experience to ensure it is construction-specific (Geofencing, Cost Codes).
 - **Job Costing Engine:** The logic that allocates burdened labor to projects is our competitive moat. We must own the math that says "Job A gets \$500 of burden."
 - **Compliance Logic (Prevailing Wage):** We must build the rules engine that overrides base rates with prevailing wages.
- **Buy / Partner (Integration):**
 - **Tax Engine:** Maintaining tax tables for 50 states and thousands of localities is resource-intensive. We should integrate with a headless payroll provider (e.g., Check, Gusto Embedded) or a tax filing service (e.g., MasterTax, Symmetry) to handle the calculation and remittance of taxes.¹⁴
 - **Regulatory Reporting:** For specialized forms like W-2s and 1099s, we should leverage integrations with established providers like **Atrix**, who specialize in keeping forms up-to-date with changing regulations.¹⁴

6.2 Security and Privacy

- **PII Protection:** All sensitive data (SSNs, Bank Accounts) must be encrypted at rest and in transit using AES-256 encryption. This addresses specific weaknesses identified in legacy systems like Vista.¹⁴
- **Role-Based Access Control (RBAC):** Granular permissions are essential. A Field Supervisor must be able to approve hours but *never* see the pay rates or salaries of their crew members. An external CPA needs read-only access to reports but no ability to initiate payments.¹⁴

7. Go-to-Market Strategy and Roadmap

7.1 Phase 1: The "Simple" Builder (MVP) - Months 1-6

- **Target:** 1-10 Employees, Residential Contractors, Non-Union, Single State.
- **Features:** Mobile time tracking, Basic Gross-to-Net, Direct Deposit, Automated Tax Filing (Federal/State), Basic Job Costing.
- **Goal:** Capture the "low hanging fruit"—contractors moving off spreadsheets who prioritize ease of use over complex compliance.
- **Geography:** Launch in a business-friendly state with high construction volume and lower regulatory complexity, such as **Texas**.¹⁴

7.2 Phase 2: The "Growing" Contractor - Months 6-12

- **Target:** 10-50 Employees, Commercial Subcontractors, Light Public Works.
- **Features:** Certified Payroll Reports (WH-347), Prevailing Wage Rate management, Multi-State Reciprocity handling (e.g., crew lives in PA, works in OH).
- **Goal:** Solve the "Compliance Trap." This is the key differentiator against Gusto/QuickBooks.

7.3 Phase 3: The "Complex" Operator (Future) - Month 12+

- **Target:** 50+ Employees, Union Shops.
- **Features:** Advanced Union Reciprocity (calculating fringe benefits for multiple locals), HRIS features (Benefits Admin), Deep ERP integrations (Procore sync).
- **Goal:** Upmarket expansion.

8. Metrics Strategy

To measure the health and success of Prism Payroll, we will track the following KPIs:

8.1 Adoption Metrics

- **Attach Rate:** The percentage of new Prism Accounting customers who also purchase Prism Payroll. Target: 30% in Year 1.
- **Activation Time:** The time from "Sign Up" to "First Payroll Run." Target: <5 days for MVP cohort.
- **Mobile Engagement:** Monthly Active Users (MAU) of the mobile app divided by total active employees. A high ratio indicates successful field adoption.

8.2 Operational Metrics

- **Correction Rate:** The frequency of payroll runs that are "unlocked" and edited after submission. A high rate indicates friction in the time approval workflow.⁵
- **Support Volume:** Ticket volume per active customer. A spike here indicates the "intuitive" requirement is not being met.

8.3 Financial Metrics

- **Churn Rate:** Specific focus on "Involuntary Churn" (business failure) vs. "Voluntary Churn" (switching to competitor).
- **Revenue per Employee (PEPM):** Average revenue generated per active employee on the platform.

9. Pricing Strategy

The pricing model must be transparent and competitive with the "Generalist" market while capturing the value of the "Specialist" features.

- **Structure:** Base Fee + Per Employee Per Month (PEPM) fee.
- **Base Fee:** \$50/month. (Comparable to Gusto Plus at \$80 or QuickBooks Premium at \$75).³³
- **PEPM:** \$8/employee/month.
- **Differentiation:** Unlike competitors who charge extra for "Time Tracking" or "Advanced Reporting," Prism should bundle the Mobile App and Job Costing into the core price. This creates a compelling value proposition: "All the construction tools you need, one price."

10. Conclusion

Prism Construction Payroll represents a strategic opportunity to solve a deep-seated pain point for the 3.7 million SMB contractors in the US. By rejecting the complexity of legacy ERPs and adding the necessary "construction muscle" to the user-friendly model of modern SaaS payroll, Prism can own the "Missing Middle" of the market.

The key to success is **discipline in scoping**. We must resist the urge to build features for the 500-person union contractor in Phase 1. We must focus relentlessly on the 10-person remodeling crew, giving them a tool that feels like it was built for them—simple, mobile, and safe. By automating the compliance burdens that keep owners awake at night, Prism will transition from being a software vendor to being a trusted partner in their business growth.

Summary Table: Prism Payroll vs. Competitors

Feature	Prism Payroll	QuickBooks Payroll	Gusto	Foundation / Vista
Target Audience	SMB Construction	Generic SMB	Generic SMB	Enterprise Construction
Job Costing	Native &	Basic / Limited	Basic	Deep

	Deep			
Certified Payroll	Automated (Native)	Workaround Required	Manual / 3rd Party	Automated
Mobile App	Field-First Design	Integrated (TSheets)	Generic	Often Clunky
Usability	High	High	High	Low
Setup Time	Days	Hours/Days	Hours	Months
Price	\$\$	\$\$	\$\$	\$\$\$\$

This MRD serves as the blueprint for development, positioning Prism to become the definitive payroll solution for the SMB construction market.

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